

escape the cycles of violence and retribution in which we are caught up. J. Denny Weaver resists God-ward directions of Jesus' death, in which God requires the death of an individual, and positions Jesus' death and resurrection as a non-violent victory through which Jesus overcomes the violence of evil. Especially useful in this chapter is Weaver's taxonomy of the different directions of atonement theories and his intricate treatment of God's use of violence to undo violence. The very nature of the confrontation between the peaceful, non-violent life of God in Christ and the reign of evil makes Jesus' death 'inevitable' (p. 352). An extensive essay by Andrew Klager views Irenaeus' theology of atonement and the restoration of humanity through his grasp of Christ's non-violence. God in Christ being non-violent, and God in Christ reconciling humanity, God cannot logically direct his wrath towards his Son, unless we wish to be left with the absurdity of a 'God violently killing his own nonviolent self in an effort to demonstrate the importance of nonviolence to the humanity he wishes to redeem – through violence' (p. 446). This exposition is well complemented by Kharalambos Anstall's setting out the foreignness of the legalistic mindset of satisfaction models to Eastern Orthodoxy.

The various essays in this volume congregate around the conviction of Richard Rohr (quoted in Sharon Baker's essay) 'that God's justice is not achieved by punishment, but by the divine initiative we call grace' (p. 233). The grace of the cross is the more incredible because it is not part of the world's logic of violence, coming to us as costly and extravagant. The range of perspectives on the cross as non-violent, from the patristic world to the streets of Honduras, makes this a very rich resource for rethinking penal understandings of Jesus' death and his dismantling of the logic of violence. Nor does the book present one single party-line: readers will notice that various essays could be usefully brought into critical interaction with one another. (The volume could have been further enriched by a contribution from a contemporary writer advocating some notion of penal substitution.) Although the essays range in their accessibility, many of them would be excellent for introducing students to alternative views on Jesus' saving death. This is a timely and provocative book.

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Frederiek Depoortere, *Christ in Postmodern Philosophy: Gianni Vattimo, René Girard and Slavoj Žižek*. London: T. & T. Clark, 2008, viii + 159pp. £16.99

It used to be the case that the claims made by the so-called postmodern movement (however broadly defined) were deemed to conflict with the basic tenets of religious thought. However, of late we are experiencing a deliberate 'turn to religion' within the fold of postmodern thinking. In light of the original antagonism supposed to exist between the two modes of thought, little has been done to collate points of overlap between the two. It is this interstice in scholarship that Frederiek

Depoortere seeks to fill with his work on the utilization of the person of Jesus Christ within postmodern thought.

In his introduction, Depoortere clearly delineates his project: 'The present book offers an investigation into the Christological reflections of three contemporary thinkers, namely Gianni Vattimo, René Girard and Slavoj Žižek' (p. 1). The precise route Depoortere will take through the thought of these three scholars is carefully situated around two unmistakable loci: 'In what follows, we will investigate the Christological ideas of these three contemporary thinkers, focusing on the topics of the relation between transcendence and the event of the incarnation on the one hand, and the topic of the uniqueness of Christianity on the other' (p. 2). However, as shall become apparent, this initial clarity becomes somewhat indistinct in the course of the account. The book itself is divided into three chapters, each one devoted to the three scholars in question. Each chapter begins with a helpful *précis* of the thinker's immediate context and the main trajectories of his thought, before exploring the christological proposals developed by each philosopher. Every chapter ends with an evaluation of the resulting Christologies with positive and negative elements being teased out of each. The book ends with a 'General Conclusion' in which the theological usefulness of each thinker is discussed.

The opening chapter is devoted to Gianni Vattimo. After situating Vattimo's writing within his strict Roman Catholic background and his appropriation of the philosophies of Heidegger and Nietzsche, Depoortere offers an account of Vattimo's kenotic Christology which leads to the defining principle of '*caritas*'. By conceiving of all metaphysical thought as 'inherently violent', Vattimo suggests that the only way humankind can escape from such violence is through *caritas* which is 'an active commitment to diminishing violence in all of its forms' (*After Christianity*, p. 48). Christ's primary role in such a narrative is in revealing the violence which had become intrinsic to human existence. However, in terms of its material content, this begins to look more and more like an 'immanentist defence of secularization'. Thus, Vattimo ultimately defines Christianity as a 'legitimization of the abandonment of Christianity'. At this point, Depoortere argues that Vattimo has only succeeded in losing Christianity within the more lacklustre morass of 'religion' and it is from here that he leads into discussion of the work of Girard and Žižek in search of a more robust account of 'the uniqueness of Christianity' and 'a Christology which is rooted in a non-Christian anthropology' (p. 33).

The second chapter attempts to offer René Girard's mimetic account of human anthropology as a solution to the breakdown of Vattimo's Christology. As becomes apparent, Depoortere approves both of Girard's account of transcendent love as an account of divine transcendence, and also of his model of mimetic desire, which is not developed *ab abstracto* but finds a place within modern scientific research. This latter facet takes up the discussion for a number of pages (63–84), locating Girard's anthropology within more precise scientific discussion. Girard's own Christology is explored by means of a comparison with Nietzsche's famous dichotomy of 'Dionysus versus the Crucified One'. Depoortere is sympathetic to Nietzsche's own formulation, suggesting Girard reads Nietzsche through the framework provided by

his own mimetic model, but ultimately sides with Girard, stating 'if humankind wants to survive its own violence, there is only one option: siding with the Crucified One, against Dionysus' (p. 60). For Girard, Christology focuses on the transcendence of Christ over the violent principles at the heart of human anthropological tradition. The chapter ends with a defence of Girard against the claims of John Milbank.

In the final chapter, on Slavoj Žižek, Depoortere (somewhat confusingly) relates what he has so far explored in the Christologies of Vattimo and Girard to Žižek's own wider writings. After describing Christ in the Žižekian framework of the *objet petit a*, Depoortere is led to fault him for causing the same problems as Vattimo, namely not giving an adequate account of divine transcendence. In fact, the only redeeming feature of Žižek's own account of Christology, according to Depoortere, is in his notion of the uniqueness of Christianity, for which he is criticized for being too 'supercessionist' (p. 139). At this point, Depoortere seems to have lost his way a little: his chapter on Žižek seems to add little to the argument and leads the reader to question why he didn't reverse the second and third chapters providing Girard as the 'saviour' with his mimetic theory and transcendent Christology.

It is precisely at this point, in determining the author's overall argument that the coherence of the book seems to come into question. Throughout the book's line of reasoning, one is left asking what the author is attempting to do. Whilst it becomes obvious that Girard is the champion, it seems odd that the chapter devoted to him falls out of place. The author himself admits, in the introduction, that this work was prompted by his own doctoral research which focused on a broad field of thinkers: Caputo, Kearney, Vattimo, Westphal and Žižek (p. 1). It is surprising to me that Depoortere chose to include Vattimo and Žižek, whom he placed in the same group in his doctoral work, rather than choosing, say, Caputo as a contrasting interlocutor. This problem is compounded by Depoortere's own stumbling with respect to Žižek's account of the *objet petit a*. By his own admission, Depoortere struggles to understand this. 'Žižek is not very clear on this point (and maybe he did not even have the intention to stretch his comparison as far as we are attempting to do here)' (p. 119). However, in Depoortere's defence, his book was released in advance of the combined effort of Žižek and Milbank, *The Monstrosity of Christ*, in which Žižek's own Christology is discussed in far more detail.

Nevertheless, the structure of the work notwithstanding, this book offers very good basic introduction to the thought of both Gianni Vattimo and René Girard and, subsequently, offers a good account of the current direction within the postmodern 'turn to religion'. The book ultimately suffers by its own shortness which does not allow Depoortere to develop his own critique to the extent that might be desired. His critique also relies perhaps too heavily on secondary literature from the narrower spectrum of Dutch-language scholarship. This book would be a useful tool for the lecturer who wants students to get a good grasp of postmodern Christology, but might perhaps leave higher-level readers wanting more.

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